

Cited and adapted from: <https://pressbooks.pub/speakingconfidently/chapter/developing-arguments/>
and <https://helpfulprofessor.com/types-of-evidence-in-writing/>

Developing Arguments for the Persuasive Speech

Part II Evidence

Evidence is the proof or support for your claim. It answers the question, “how do I know this is true?” With any type of evidence, there are three overarching considerations.

First, is this the most timely and relevant type of support for my claim? If your evidence isn’t timely (or has been disproven), it may drastically influence the credibility of your claim.

Second, is this evidence relatable and clear for my audience? Your audience should be able to understand the evidence, including any references or ideas within your information. Have you ever heard a joke or insight about a television show that you’ve never seen? If so, understanding the joke can be difficult. The same is true for your audience, so stay focused on their knowledge base and level of understanding.

Third, did I cherry-pick? Avoid cherry-picking evidence to support your claims. While we’ve discussed claims first, it’s important to arrive at a claim after seeing all the evidence (i.e. doing the research). Rather than finding evidence to fit your idea (cherry-picking), the evidence should help you arrive at the appropriate claim. Cherry-picking evidence can reduce your ethos and weakened your argument.

With these insights in mind, we will introduce you to six evidence types: Evidence can come from many sources and take many forms, but generally speaking, there are six types of evidence. Choosing which type of evidence to use depends on the purpose of communication and the audience. Ideally, it is good to have a mix of the different types of evidence. Using various types of evidence also shows that you have researched the topic thoroughly. That will add credibility as a whole and instill an impression that the author is competent and trustworthy.

1. Anecdotal Evidence

Anecdotal evidence comes from personal experience. It can involve a story about something that happened to you, or an observation you made about friends, relatives, or other people. An informal interview with someone affected by the topic you are writing about is also a form of anecdotal evidence. That interview may have been conducted by the author of the essay or presented on a news program.

Although it is not considered very strong evidence, it does have a purpose. Describing a personal experience early in the essay can help establish context, show relevance of the subject, or be a way to build a connection with the audience. In some cases, anecdotal evidence can be quite effective. It can reveal deeply personal or emotional elements of a phenomenon that are very compelling. Not all essays need to be full of scientific references and statistics to be effective at making a point.

2. Testimonial Evidence

Offering the opinion of an expert is referred to as testimonial evidence. Their opinion can come from an interview or quote from a book or paper they authored. The words of someone who is considered an expert in a subject can provide a lot of support to the point you are trying to make. It adds strength and shows that what you are saying is not just your opinion, but is also the opinion of someone that is recognized and respected in the subject.

If that expert has an advanced degree from a notable university, such as Princeton or Stanford, then make sure the reader knows that. Similarly, if they are the president or director of an institution that is heavily involved in the subject, then be sure to include those credentials as well. If your essay is for an academic course, use proper citation. This often involves indicating the year of the quote, where it was published, and the page number where the quote comes from. Finally, if quoting an expert, choose the quote carefully. Experts sometimes use language that is overly complex or contains jargon that many readers may not understand. Limiting the quote to 1 or 2 sentences is also a good idea.

3. Statistical Evidence

Statistical evidence involves presenting numbers that support your point. Statistics can be used to demonstrate the prevalence and seriousness of a phenomenon. When used early in the essay, it informs the reader as to how important the topic is and can be an effective way to get the reader's attention. For example, citing the number of people that die each year because they weren't wearing a seat belt, or the number of children suffering from malnutrition, tells the reader that the topic is serious. Statistics can also be used to counter common misconceptions. This is a good way to clear the air right away regarding an issue that may not be well understood or in which there has been a lot of misinformation presented previously.

When presenting statistics, establish credibility by citing the source. Make sure that source is reputable. Scientific publications or well-respected organizations such as the CDC are good examples. If your essay is for an academic assignment, then be sure to follow the publication guidelines for that discipline. Papers in business, sociology, and law have different rules for how to cite sources.

4. Textual Evidence

Textual evidence comes directly from a source document. This could be a literary work or historical document. It is frequently used in an argumentative essay or as part of a compare-and-contrast type of academic assignment. For example, if conducting a character analysis of a character in a novel, then identifying key sentences that provide examples of their personality will help support your analysis.

There are several ways of incorporating textual evidence: quoting, paraphrasing, and summarizing. Quoting statements from the character themselves can be used to demonstrate their thought processes or personality flaws. Likewise, using the words of the author that describe the character will add support to your premise. Paraphrasing involves conveying the points in the source

document by using your own words. Summarizing involves condensing the text in the source document to its main points and highlighting the key takeaways you want the reader to focus on.

5. Analogical Evidence

An analogy is an example of a situation, but presented in a different context. Using an analogy is a great way to explain a complicated issue that is simpler and easier to digest. Medical doctors often use analogies to describe health-related issues. For example, they might say that getting a yearly medical exam from your primary physician is like taking your car to the mechanic once a year to make sure everything is running okay.

One rule of thumb about analogies is that the simpler they are, the more easily understood. Be careful not to use an analogy that is too far-fetched. For example, comparing the human body to the universe is too much of a stretch. This might confuse the reader, make them feel frustrated because they don't see the connection, and/or cause them to lose interest.

6. Hypothetical Evidence

Hypothetical evidence is presenting the reader with a "what if" kind of scenario. This is a great way to get the reader to consider possibilities that they may not have thought of previously. One way to present a hypothetical is to pair it with a credible statistic. Ask the reader to consider what might happen in the context of those numbers. Another strategy is to restate one of your arguments, and then present a hypothetical that aligns with that point. For example, if what you are saying is true, then X, Y, and Z may occur.

By providing a concrete hypothetical scenario, people can imagine what could happen. Opening a person's mindset can be the first step towards an effective and persuasive essay.

There are many examples in history of phenomenon that people never thought possible, but later turned out to materialize. For example, climate change. In the early days of climate science, the evidence was not readily available to a convincing degree to persuade the general public. However, extrapolating into the future through the use of hypotheticals can help people consider the possibility of fossil fuels causing climate crises. The emotional dynamics activated when thinking about the future can help open some people's eyes to different possibilities and generate concern. If only this had happened about 50 years ago.

Providing evidence for your claims can make your argument effective and persuasive. There are many types of evidence, and each one varies in terms of its strength and pertinence. Incorporating several types of evidence is best. If all arguments in an essay only come from the author, it can come across as flimsy. A chair with three legs is better than a chair with two.

Vocabulary

序号	单词	中文释义	例句
1	evidence	n. 证据; 证明	The report lacks concrete evidence to support its conclusion.
2	anecdotal	adj. 轶事的; 传闻的	Anecdotal evidence suggests that the new policy has improved working conditions.
3	testimonial	adj. 证明的; n. 证词; 推荐书	The product received positive testimonial from industry experts.
4	statistical	adj. 统计的; 统计学的	Statistical data shows a steady increase in online shopping.
5	textual	adj. 文本的; 原文的	The researcher provided textual evidence to back up his argument.
6	analogical	adj. 类比的; 类推的	Analogical reasoning can help explain complex scientific concepts.
7	hypothetical	adj. 假设的; 假定的	The professor put forward a hypothetical scenario to stimulate discussion.
8	competent	adj. 有能力的; 能胜任的	Only competent candidates will be considered for the position.
9	trustworthy	adj. 可靠的; 值得信赖的	A trustworthy friend will always keep your secrets.
10	prevalence	n. 流行; 普遍	The prevalence of obesity has become a major public health issue.
11	misconception	n. 误解; 错误观念	There is a common misconception that all snakes are poisonous.
12	reputable	adj. 声誉好的; 受尊敬的	We should only get information from reputable sources.
13	citation	n. 引用; 引文; 传票	Proper citation of sources is essential in academic writing.
14	paraphrase	v. 释义; 改述; n. 释义; 复述	You can paraphrase the original text but must still cite the source.
15	digest	v. 消化; 理解; n. 摘要; 文摘	It takes time to digest all the information from the meeting.
16	far-fetched	adj. 牵强的; 不切	His explanation for being late was too far-fetched

序号	单词	中文释义	例句
		实际的	to believe.
17	scenario	n. 设想; 可能发生的情况	The company prepared for various emergency scenarios.
18	pertinent	n. 相关的; 恰当的	The speaker failed to explain why his example was pertinent to the topic.
19	flimsy	adj. 脆弱的; 薄弱的; 易损坏的	The argument he presented was based on flimsy evidence.
20	extrapolate	v. 推断; 外推	We can extrapolate future trends from past data.
21	materialize	v. 实现; 出现; 具体化	His dream of becoming a doctor finally materialized after years of hard work.
22	credential	n. 资格证书; 资历	She presented her credentials to prove she was qualified for the job.
23	condense	v. 浓缩; 精简; 凝结	You need to condense the 10-page report into a 2-page summary.
24	compelling	adj. 引人入胜的; 有说服力的	The documentary presented compelling evidence of environmental pollution.
25	validate	v. 证实; 验证; 使生效	Scientists need to validate their findings through repeated experiments.
26	substantiate	v. 证实; 证明	The witness provided new details to substantiate the suspect's guilt.
27	cohesive	adj. 连贯的; 有结合力的	A good essay should have a cohesive structure that connects all paragraphs.
28	contextual	adj. 上下文的; 情境的	To understand this sentence, you need to consider its contextual meaning.
29	infer	v. 推断; 推论	Readers can infer the author's attitude from the tone of the article.
30	corroborate	v. 证实; 支持	The new data corroborates the earlier research on climate change.

Exercise

I Fill in the blanks using the most appropriate words from the vocabulary.

1. When writing an argumentative essay, you should only select examples that are _____ to your main point; irrelevant details will weaken your argument.

2. A common _____ about statistical evidence is that "all numbers are credible," but in fact, unqualified data can be misleading.
3. The _____ of using anecdotal evidence alone in academic papers has decreased, as more students realize the need for diverse evidence types.
4. When analyzing a literary work, it is important to consider the _____ background of the author to understand the text better.
5. From the author's description of the character's actions, we can _____ that he is hiding something important.

II Circle the most suitable choice to replace the underlined word.

1. The student needs to condense the long article into a short summary for the presentation.
A. expand B. simplify C. lengthen D. elaborate
2. The argument he made was based on flimsy proof that could not convince the audience.
A. solid B. weak C. convincing D. detailed
3. The professor asked us to paraphrase the complex paragraph in our own words.
A. quote directly B. explain briefly
C. rewrite in different words D. memorize exactly
4. It takes time to digest all the new information from the training course.
A. understand and process B. forget and ignore
C. collect and store D. share and discuss
5. The far-fetched idea he proposed was rejected by the committee immediately.
A. practical B. reasonable C. unrealistic D. creative

III Translate the following sentences into Chinese/ English.

1. 在议论文写作中，只有引用权威数据和文献，才能充分证实自己提出的核心论点。
(substantiate)
2. 在解读文学作品中的对话时，应结合人物关系、故事场景等情境信息来理解其隐含意思。
(contextual)
3. 研究者总结过去二十年里心理健康问题的统计数据，为相关问题提供了关键的证据支持。
(extrapolate)
4. 在使用假设证据时，应通过具体的案例和描述，让假设的情况转化为可感知的内容。
(materialize)
5. 来自普通民众亲身经历的、引人入胜的轶事，比冰冷的数字更能让读者产生情感共鸣。
(compelling)